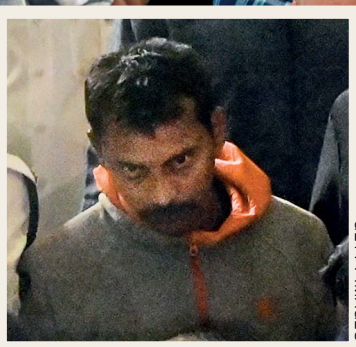




GETTY IMAGES

BLAMING THE POWERS Protesters demand justice for the RG Kar victim in Kolkata, Jan. 18; inset, Sanjay Roy after hearing his punishment in court; Jan. 20

mitted the gruesome crime. He had no prior motive, the probe found.

The autopsy concluded that the victim died from "manual strangulation associated with smothering". Das emphasised "associated", indicating throttling as the primary cause and smothering as a concurrent factor. Marks of pressure from a thumb and fingertips suggested strangulation through the perpetrator's right hand, while abrasions on the victim's lips—caused by friction against her dental braces—corroborated smothering. Defence arguments that throttling and smothering could not occur simultaneously were refuted, with experts clarifying that they could logically overlap. The lack of injuries on the victim's back supported the conclusion of a frontal assault. Evidence of asphyxial death—such as bleeding from the eyes and nose—and its co-occurence with multiple nail marks from one individual is consistent with the idea of manual strangulation by a single person, rather than the popular theory of it being a gang rape.

Roy's culpability was established through a combination of forensic evidence, CCTV footage and his contradictory statements. Footage captured Roy entering the third floor of the Emergency Building, where the seminar room was located, between 4:03 and 4:31 a.m. on August 9. He was seen carrying a helmet and Bluetooth earphone, though the latter was missing upon his exit. Investigators found Roy's Bluetooth earphone at the crime scene. Metadata confirmed continuous pairing of the device with his phone, which Roy failed to explain. Photographs of the mattress and dais suggested the earphone had slipped beneath the mattress during the assault.

Forensic evidence also implicated Roy. Bloodstains on his jeans and footwear matched the victim's DNA, and strands of hair linked them. Abrasions on his face, thighs and fingers were consistent with the victim's struggle.

Although many believed the seminar room was not the scene of the crime, this too was not upheld. The victim's father had cited an inspection report that found no biological stains on the floor or signs of struggle on the mattress, but the court noted that key evidence had been collected earlier. Crucial material, including bed sheets, blankets and mattress samples, had been seized on the day of the crime—by the police. Photographs and videos from the inquest showed marks of struggle on the victim's bed sheet, bolstering the conclusion of the seminar room being the crime scene. Also, the forensic team tested samples from an adjacent room that also attracted some contentious attention: located a few feet away from the seminar room, this area had started being "renovated" on August 13 , three days after the rape-murder. As part of this, a wall in front of the seminar room was demolished. It was alleged that this was done to tamper with the evidence, but no biological trace related to the crime was found from the area.

The assault's brutality was underscored by injuries that indicated the victim was alive during much of her ordeal. Experts confirmed rape, describing injuries caused by the insertion of an unknown blunt object. The absence of semen or male pubic hair meant penile penetration could not be established, but the evidence left no doubt about the victim's suffering. One of the most contentious issues was a claim that 151 grams of semen had been recovered from the victim. But tests on some white, thick liquid found in the victim confirmed it was not semen, though its exact nature remains undetermined. The accumulated evidence—ranging from DNA matches and injuries to the weak defence—left no doubt about Roy's guilt.

The victim's parents rejected the court-directed Rs 17 lakh compensation, asserting that chief minister Mamata Banerjee cannot "disown responsibilities". It drew criticism from the Trinamool Congress, which accused them of being "the voice of conspiracy against the West Bengal government". The verdict severely criticised the state administration—Tala Police station in Kolkata, which first probed the crime, the poor forensic infrastructure and RG Kar Medical College and Hospital principal Sandip Ghosh and others, who were accused of hiding the truth. But allegations directly linking Mamata and her administration with the crime ultimately stood discarded. Politically, Mamata has not merely weathered the severest storm of public outrage she has faced—she has emerged with a striking piece of external validation. ■

THEORY AND PROOF

- **The prime accused in the RG Kar rape-murder case, Sanjay Roy, sentenced to life imprisonment**
- **In contrast to the popular narrative of gang rape, the CBI probe concluded that Roy had acted alone**
- **The seminar room was scene of crime; no semen found in victim–both contrary to what many were led to believe**